

Inaugural Lecture – Professor Dr. Peter Lugtig

Delivered on 2 April 2026, Utrecht, on the occasion of the acceptance of the Chair in *Data Quality*

Madam Rector, distinguished colleagues, esteemed guests,

I would like to speak to you today about *data quality*. If all goes well, you will see English subtitles appear on the screens besides me—provided, of course, that the technology does not fail us, and that I speak clearly enough. The program producing the translation must first transform my spoken words into written text, and then render that Dutch text into English—all without having any real understanding of where my argument is headed.

Much can go wrong in the translation from Dutch into English—as I can already reveal, it almost certainly will, especially toward the end. Errors might occur in converting my speech into written text, for instance if I speak too quickly or indistinctly. Over the next forty-five minutes, I shall try to ensure that *high-quality data* emerge from my mouth. If that fails, I can always blame the translation system.

Data are nothing other than information that we use for some purpose. We rely on data to make everyday decisions, but also to shape policy and take choices of great consequence. We use data on educational performance to decide at what level of secondary school to place children, and to design the social safety net in the Netherlands. But you, too, used data just now when deciding whether or not to put on that cardigan in this hall. We use data always and everywhere.

In the next forty-five minutes, I wish to argue that *data quality* encompasses far more than the question of whether numbers “roughly add up.” I will also explain why, even in an era preoccupied with pressing global issues such as war in Europe, the Middle East, and climate change, universities must address new questions concerning the quality of data—particularly within the social sciences.

To hold meaningful public discussions on issues like poverty, it is essential that we base them on good and independent data. Reliable, collectively accepted facts can help prevent societal debates from talking past one another—especially in an age when some tend to regard all data they encounter as equally trustworthy.

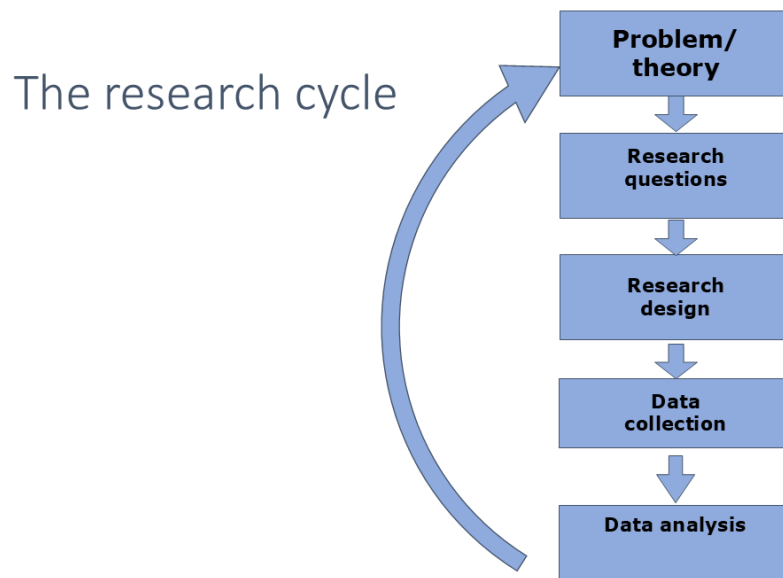
Methodology — How Do We Conduct Research?

Let me begin at the beginning. I work here in Utrecht, within the Faculty of Social and Behavioural Sciences, where we study questions that are central to the challenges of our time. How can we ensure that children grow up well? How can we develop better treatments for depression and other mental health problems? How can we understand and counteract the many forms of inequality that exist in our society? For almost eighty years, social scientists in Utrecht have been investigating such questions. While the specific topics have evolved over time, these are questions that my predecessors were already asking sixty years ago.

The way we approach these questions also shows striking continuity. Part of the social sciences has always been concerned with *theory formation*: reflecting on what concepts such as inequality actually mean. Does inequality refer purely to material differences, or also to less visible forms, such as differences in health or digital access? Our society constantly changes, and with new perspectives we can reconsider longstanding problems in new ways.

Another part of the discipline is devoted to *description and empirical testing*. Scholars observe how inequality can be measured, how it evolves, and which groups are affected. This strand of social science seeks to *describe* and *explain* reality. The best scholars often combine both orientations: they develop theories to illuminate how inequality might arise and then proceed to test whether those theories fit the empirical world.

Over the past century, ideas have developed about how to conduct such research well—ideas that align with this interplay between theory-building and empirical testing. First-year social science students in Utrecht become very familiar with a classic diagram, derived from the work of the Dutch methodologist Adriaan de Groot. I believe it fitting to show it again here.

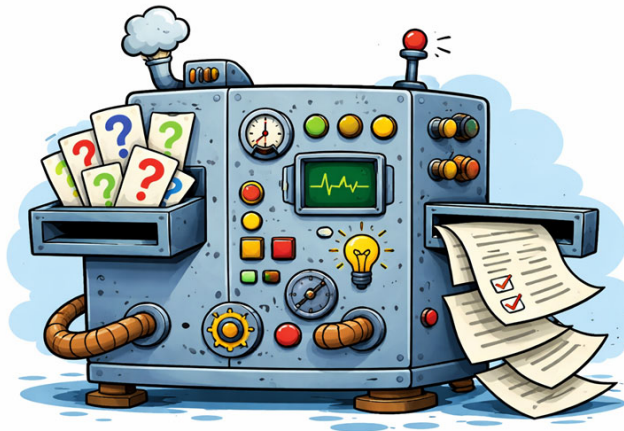


The research process can be summarized into what we call *the empirical cycle*. Two ideas lie at its core. First, research is not a one-off process but a *cycle*: answering questions often leads to new questions, and through successive iterations we gradually build collective knowledge. Second, within a single study there are a series of logical, interconnected steps. If each step is executed carefully, the research will yield sound results. High-quality data, in this view, are the natural outcome of a well-designed research process.

In today's lecture, I shall focus particularly on the step in which the researcher reflects on *research design*. This is the domain of *methodology*: how to ensure that the methods we use lead us toward valid, scientific answers to our research questions.

I like to portray research design—the manner in which a study is executed—as a *data machine*. You feed a question into the machine, and if you calibrate the machine correctly—by pressing the right methodological buttons—it will ultimately produce a sound, well-founded answer. To obtain high-quality data, one must therefore construct a good *data machine*.

Research design: the data machine



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Consider an example. Suppose a researcher wishes to know whether antidepressants combined with therapy are more effective in treating depression than therapy alone. In such a case, an experiment is the obvious method. Or imagine a study aimed at understanding people's opinions; then one might conduct interviews—either structured through questionnaires or open-ended in nature.

For every research method developed during the twentieth century, there now exists a set of rules and principles—or with a modern term *best practices*. For experiments, you may recall the importance of *random assignment* of participants to experimental conditions, ideally without either the participants or the researcher knowing who receives which treatment as an example of such a best practice

All these rules can be summarized within the concept of the *data machine*: we obtain good data when we build the machine properly and follow its procedures diligently. Fortunately, that is often the case in scientific practice. Yet over the past decades, the world of research has undergone major

changes—changes that explain why I stand before you today and you sit here listening. Something in our *machine* has begun to falter.

When the Data Machine Falters

Over the past thirty years, roughly coinciding with the massive digital transformation brought about by the Internet, something fundamental has changed in the conduct of much social-scientific research.

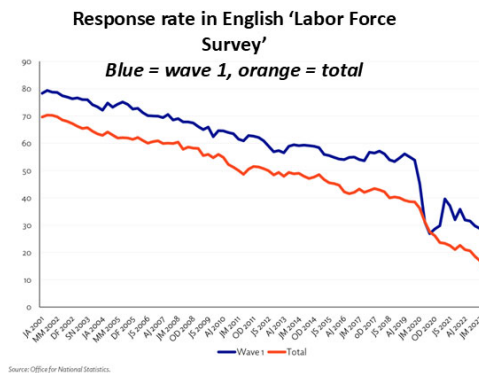
Three developments stand out.

1. There is an ever-increasing demand for information—information that must not only be accurate but also available sooner and at lower cost.
2. The difficulties inherent in social research—particularly those related to recruiting participants and measuring what we truly intend to measure—have intensified.
3. Finally, there is an unprecedented proliferation of available data.

Let me dwell briefly on each of these three challenges.

Why does the data machine falter?

1. Growing need for information
2. Difficulties in research
3. More data ‘freely’ available



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The Expanding Demand for Information

The growing demand for information comes not only from science itself but, perhaps more urgently, from society at large. Governments, corporations, and civil-society organizations alike are engaged in programmes of *data-driven decision-making*, often under the assumption that more data will enhance the quality—or, more often still, the *efficiency*—of their work or policies.

At every purchase we make, we are asked to leave a review; policy development routinely draws on opinion surveys to measure public support; and in education, student performance is continuously monitored. Whether all this data collection is genuinely useful is sometimes debatable—it often is, but frequently not. What matters here is that the appetite for data is still growing. Yet conducting sound research remains time-consuming and costly, and the resources available are limited.

The Increasing Difficulties of Social Research

The second challenge concerns the well-known, but now worsening, methodological difficulties of research. People do not always give honest answers when questioned. On some topics—such as how many steps they have taken today—they may simply not know the answer. A newer and increasingly serious problem is that people are ever less willing to participate in studies at all. The problem of *nonresponse* is becoming acute in virtually all forms of research.

On the screen to my right you see the response rate for the British Labour Force Survey, a key instrument used to estimate unemployment. In the United Kingdom, participation in this survey has declined from about 80 percent in 2001 to around 30 percent in 2023, and only 15 percent of respondents complete the full study. Is that problematic? A low response rate is not necessarily fatal, but in Britain it has coincided with large fluctuations in unemployment estimates—so severe that analysts have on several occasions deemed the data unfit for use. And that, of course, *is* problematic, for such data underpin government policy on taxation and social benefits.

Although the British case is still exceptional, declining response rates can be observed in nearly all forms of survey research. Since the COVID-19 pandemic, concerns have grown that particular social groups are no longer being reached effectively by academic surveys at all.

There are solutions, of course. Researchers can invest more effort in recruitment—but that makes research increasingly expensive. Other remedies must therefore align with the underlying reasons why people are less inclined to participate. I shall return to this later.

A Deluge of Digital Data

The third development is the explosion of available data—much of it freely accessible. The digital revolution, and the Internet in particular, have generated enormous quantities of information. The data available on social-media platforms, for example, may hold valuable clues for understanding patterns of parenting in the Netherlands; many of us sense that intuitively. We can, for instance, quantify how many Dutch children maintain a personal vlog on YouTube, analyse the content of those videos, observe what they do, and determine the role their parents play. Counting can now be automated through artificial intelligence; *web-scraping* tools can harvest the data directly from the Internet.

Thus we find ourselves facing a paradox. On one side, traditional research—based on controlled sampling, carefully designed questionnaires, and meticulous fieldwork—has become more difficult and costly. On the other, we live in a world of data abundance, where digital information seems instant, plentiful, and often free.

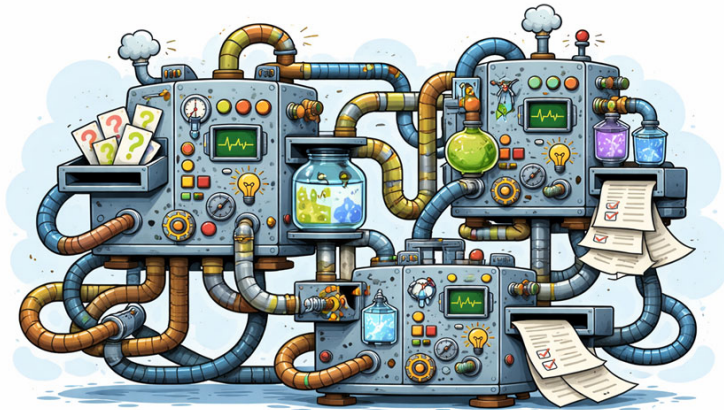
These two worlds collide. The collision may appear theoretical, but its consequences are highly practical. Many researchers now face a pressing dilemma: should they adhere to traditional methodologies—such as surveys—or switch to the use of *new data sources* and *big data* to answer their questions? The temptation is strong, yet the path forward is unclear.

We live, in short, in a time of *data in abundance*—but the central question remains: what should we do with it?

How Should We Proceed?

There is a clear need for a new “data machine”—one that does not replace the traditional systems we have relied upon, but rather complements and extends them. The central question, then, is how to design such a system in a rigorous and meaningful way. This is precisely the challenge that will guide my research and teaching in the years to come.

A new datamachine?



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What might such a new data machine look like? It will undoubtedly be far more complex than its predecessors. Contemporary researchers increasingly combine existing data with a wide range of newly generated digital data sources, often in highly flexible ways. The manner in which this is done depends strongly on the research question at hand and on the data available. There is no single recipe for integrating and summarizing these diverse data streams. Consequently, there is no single, unified “data machine.”

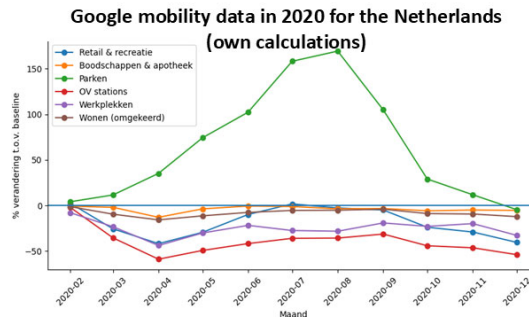
Nevertheless, let us attempt to sketch a vision. What should research methodology look like in a future where the social sciences make far more extensive use of existing and digital data?

A key distinction from earlier approaches is that we can no longer assume that data quality is guaranteed simply by carefully designing the data collection process. While such design remains important, it is no longer sufficient—particularly when data are assembled from multiple heterogeneous sources. Data quality is determined not only by the quality of each individual source, but also by the way in which these sources are combined.

This brings us to an important shift in methodological thinking in an era of data abundance. Rather than focusing primarily on the quality of the process, it is more productive to evaluate the quality of the resulting data themselves, and to reflect on the criteria they should meet. This issue has been addressed in earlier work. Paul Biemer and Lars Lyberg developed a general framework for assessing when data can be considered of high quality. While I cannot discuss their work in full here, I will highlight several key dimensions. What, then, should our ideal data look like?

Data quality: output

- Accuracy
- Timeliness
- Completeness
- Relevance
- Accessibility
- Credibility
- Completeness
- Coherence
- Interpretability



Biemer, P. P., & Lyberg, L. E. (2003). *Introduction to survey quality*. John Wiley & Sons.

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Accuracy. A central objective in science is to obtain accurate data: data that measure what we intend to measure, and do so precisely. A thermometer, for instance, should accurately measure the temperature of an oven so that we can reliably determine whether a cake is fully baked after one hour.

Timeliness. It is equally important that data become available without undue delay. Data must be timely. The social sciences are often characterized by slow data production processes, which are frequently also costly. There is a growing movement toward “slow science,” which emphasizes the value of taking time to ensure rigor and depth. While this approach is valuable for scientific inquiry, timeliness is often crucial in contexts such as policy evaluation. When rapid insights are required, we may need to accept data that are less precise. Biemer and Lyberg regard this trade-off itself as a dimension of data quality.

A practical example from work conducted in Utrecht concerns the use of data during the COVID-19 pandemic. At the onset of the pandemic, a range of public health measures were introduced: maintaining physical distance, closing public venues, limiting social contact, and working from home. Governments sought to understand, as quickly as possible, the extent to which these measures were being followed—particularly whether individuals were indeed staying at home more frequently.

One approach is to ask individuals directly, and such survey-based methods were indeed employed, for example by the Dutch National Institute for Public Health and the Environment (RIVM). However, the urgency of the situation required rapid data. Because traditional social science methods could not deliver timely information at sufficient speed, greater reliance was placed on alternative data sources, such as mobility data from Apple and Google, derived from mobile phone usage. These data illustrate changes in travel behavior—such as visits to parks, workplaces, and retail locations—over the course of the first year of the pandemic.

In collaboration with Angelo Moretti and Katharina Meitinger, I examined the quality of such data across several policy domains, as well as how data collection might be improved in future pandemics. Mobile phone data are highly timely; however, they do not precisely measure compliance with public health guidelines. They provide only coarse indicators of movement

patterns, and cannot distinguish, for example, whether an individual is visiting a location for work, social interaction, or other purposes.

Additional quality criteria further complicate the picture. Ideally, data should be **complete**. While mobile phone ownership is widespread, not everyone uses the same platforms. For instance, Google-based mobility data exclude users of other operating systems, such as Apple's, and research shows that these user groups differ not only in demographic characteristics but also in behavioral patterns. Moreover, such data assume that individuals always carry and activate their devices—an assumption that does not consistently hold. As a result, these data are far from complete.

Another important criterion is **relevance**. Even if mobility data indicate reduced travel to workplaces, they do not allow us to distinguish between different population groups, age categories, or types of occupation. For example, individuals in essential professions continued to work on-site, and this distinction is critical for policy evaluation. To capture such nuances, traditional methods such as surveys or interviews remain indispensable.

Beyond these dimensions, several additional criteria deserve mention. Some relate to the **credibility of the data producer**: data generated by an established institution such as the RIVM are generally regarded as more trustworthy than those produced by less authoritative sources. Others concern the **accessibility** of the data, their **comparability** across groups, their **interpretability**, and their **coherence**.

If we are to envision a research landscape in which multiple data sources are combined, it becomes essential to consider how such integration can enhance overall data quality. A key principle is to assess each data source in terms of its strengths and weaknesses across these quality dimensions, and then to combine sources in ways that allow the strengths of one to compensate for the limitations of another.

Through my chair in Utrecht, I aim to contribute to this endeavor in collaboration with colleagues and with a broad network of researchers engaged in the collection and analysis of social science data. In doing so, I will focus on three overarching themes, each of which I will illustrate with a concrete example.

Research Agenda — What I Intend to Do

My work as professor of data quality will focus on three broad themes:

1. Maximising the quality of data sources when the researcher retains control over the data-collection process.
2. Studying and evaluating the quality of new forms of data, and determining how such data can be validly combined or integrated.
3. Developing concrete methods for data integration, in which multiple sources are brought together within a unified analytical framework.

Example 1: The European Social Survey – Continuity in a Changing World

Before turning to examples of data integration, let me begin with a more traditional one, illustrating that not everything in our field revolves around “Big Data.” Classical approaches to research remain vital.

What to do:

1) ensure quality of traditional sources



Lugtig, P., Lensvelt-Mulders, G.J.L.M., R. Frerichs and Greven, A. (2011). [Estimating nonresponse bias and mode effects in a mixed-mode survey](#). *International Journal of Market Research*, 53, 669-686.

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Our research group in Utrecht is part of the *Core Scientific Team*—in effect, the steering committee—of the European Social Survey (ESS). This is arguably the most important European social-science research project of the past two decades. Every two years, around 40,000 people in 31 European countries are interviewed about their views on political developments, welfare, migration, and many other issues of great concern to psychologists, sociologists, and political scientists alike.

Traditionally, this survey was conducted *face-to-face*: interviewers visited respondents in their homes. At present, however, the ESS is transitioning to a *mixed-mode design*, where some respondents complete the interview online or on paper. In the coming years, our task will be to ensure that data collected before this transition remain *comparable* with those collected afterwards.

In my doctoral dissertation, I developed and applied a method on a small Dutch dataset to achieve precisely this kind of comparability. We now intend to apply and refine that approach for the ESS, the largest social-science study in Europe. Our aim is twofold: first, to ensure that the quality of the ESS data not only remains at least as high as before, but ideally improves; and second, to preserve consistency across time despite methodological change.

Example 2: The Quality of New Data – The Case of Mobility during COVID-19

The second theme of my chair connects directly to the issues discussed earlier. How good are these new digital data sources, really? Let me return briefly to the example of mobility data.

How can we know whether such data are reliable—how *accurate*, *relevant*, or *interpretable* they in fact are? How well did they capture Dutch citizens' travel behaviour during the pandemic? I have purposely postponed the answer, for a reason: it is extraordinarily difficult to determine. The data are proprietary and not publicly accessible; Google, for instance, discloses neither its algorithms nor the precise ways in which the data are aggregated.

This opacity highlights the need for scientific research into the *quality* of digital data. Not only mobility data, but also the information drawn from social media to analyse public opinion, or web-browsing data used to infer people's online activities.

A sound strategy for evaluating data quality is to compare these new digital measures with other sources intended to capture the same phenomena. By placing different datasets side by side, we can identify the points at which they agree and where they diverge.

That comparative approach represents the second pillar of my research agenda: investigating the *validity and usefulness* of emerging data sources. At present, far too little of this work is being done—even though such scrutiny is indispensable at a time when digital data, usually collected by private enterprises, increasingly inform research and policy while receiving insufficient critical examination.

What to do?

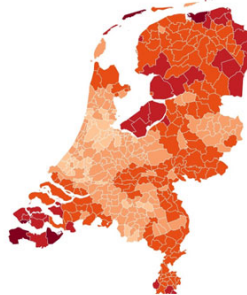
What is the quality of new data sources?



Verkeerslussen



Afstand woon-werk



Wie kiest welk vervoersmiddel?

Vervoersmiddel	Van	Tot	Afstand	Kilometer of uren?
1. Bestuurlijk	10-20	10-20	5,0	Kilometer
2. Persoon	10-20	10-20	2000,0	Uren
3. ...	10-20	10-20	...	...
4. ...	10-20	10-20	...	...

Bostanci, I, Gootzen, Y. & Lugtig, P. (2023). [Data Linkage to Validate and Calibrate Traffic Estimations on a Nationwide Scale: A Framework for Official Statistics](#). CBS discussion paper.

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You can see an example from a study conducted by Inan Bostanci, a former student of our Master's programme, supervised jointly by Yvonne Gootzen from Statistics Netherlands (CBS) and myself. In this project, multiple data sources were combined to address a central methodological question: how should we integrate them?

To the left, you can see *traffic-loop data*—sensors embedded in major roads that record the number of passing vehicles. The CBS also holds other sources: for instance, data on distances between home and workplace, and survey data about people's transport preferences, disaggregated by region and demographics such as age.

By combining these sources, we can estimate traffic intensity on all Dutch roads more accurately, and document precisely how we do this in our paper. For me, the principal intellectual gain was not simply the estimation itself, but what the project taught us: how the limitations of one data source can be compensated by another, and how the *quality* of each can be critically assessed through such comparisons.

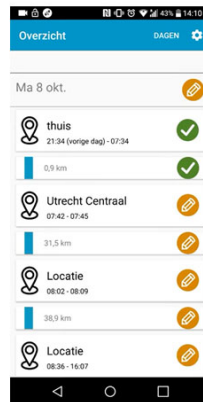
Example 3: Integrating Data Sources – Collaboration with Statistics Netherlands (CBS)

Once we have established how good the various sources are, the next logical step is to develop robust ways to *combine* them. This brings me to the third major theme of my chair.

Over the past decade, in collaboration with Statistics Netherlands (CBS), we have conducted extensive research into how *mobile-phone data* might be utilised to produce official statistics. Since the 1970s, the CBS has conducted travel diary studies, asking respondents to record all their journeys for a period of two days or a week. Participants have to log their points of departure and arrival, the times of travel, and their mode of transport—car, bicycle, train, bus, and so on. The task is laborious, and respondent fatigue is common.

What to do?

Combining traditional and new data sources



McCool, D., Lugtig, P., Mussman, O. & Schouten, J.G. (2021). [An app-assisted travel survey in official statistics. Possibilities and challenges](#). *Journal of Official Statistics*, vol. 37, 149-170. 10.2478/jos-2021-0007.

In 2018 and 2022, we tested a novel design. At its centre lies the *location sensor* in participants' mobile phones. By tracking respondents for one week via their phones, we can obtain much richer, more precise data on travel behaviour: exact departure and arrival times, routes taken, even the type of transport inferred from movement patterns. The system automatically generates a daily travel diary, which participants can then supplement—if they wish—with contextual information, such as the purpose of each trip.

Such an approach reduces respondent burden while improving data *relevance*. It exemplifies how different data sources can complement each other: we use mobile phones to capture fine-grained behavioural data, survey questions to supply information that cannot be inferred from location alone, and administrative records to correct for nonresponse bias.

In my view, this stands as a successful example of data integration at work.

Education — Teaching for a Data-Driven World

In addition to being a researcher, I am also a teacher. I greatly enjoy teaching subjects such as regression analysis and questionnaire design. Yet I am increasingly convinced that our education for social-science students requires significant renewal.

Data now play a central role in almost every domain of policymaking. Many of our graduates will not themselves become researchers, but they will nonetheless work extensively *with* data—often as policy analysts, consultants, or civil servants. At present, we do not sufficiently equip students to engage critically and effectively with the torrents of data that surround them.

We inhabit a world flooded by numbers—not only from respected institutes such as the Netherlands Institute for Social Research or Statistics Netherlands, but also from a fast-growing array of commercial actors. It is therefore essential that our students understand how data are produced, what can be inferred from them, and—equally important—what cannot.

The artificial-intelligence models that increasingly shape our daily lives are built upon vast datasets and, at their core, rely on statistical principles to perform operations such as rephrasing text, generating images, or—indeed this very evening—providing subtitles. We should not merely instruct our students about what these language models may or may not be used for during their studies; it is vital that *everyone* at the university gains a basic understanding of how such models function, so that they appreciate their limitations as well as their capabilities.

Within current curricula, there is still far too little space for what has come to be called data literacy. I consider it my responsibility, in the coming years, to help strengthen this dimension of education.

That being said, this is not to suggest that I lack confidence in our social scientists—quite the opposite. Conducting sound social-scientific research is difficult. As one of my American colleagues once remarked, reflecting on the advent of online tools that allow anyone to design their own survey: *“Any fool can now conduct a survey—and any fool does.”* I am reminded of that line often; I see, week after week, well-intentioned attempts by people who assume that devising a questionnaire is simple. Fortunately, this does not describe the majority of our students.

Social scientists are trained to think carefully about society as a whole. They not only learn what constitutes a good survey question, but also whether *everyone* can in fact answer that question, and whether people might *interpret* it differently. These skills—combining methodological rigour with sensitivity to diversity and context—are precisely the ones that remain crucial in a world marked by growing inequality and increasingly sophisticated digital tools.

I am convinced that the social sciences have much to contribute to our collective reflection on how artificial intelligence can and should be used in society.

Conclusion and Acknowledgments

This brings me to my final remarks. Science is never a solitary endeavour. I stand here today only because of the many people—within and beyond the university—with whom I have worked, who have supported me, and who have inspired me in both my teaching and research. Without them, I would quite literally not be here.

I hold a strong conviction that *both* education and research improve when they are done in teams. Within a team, others can assist you in areas where your own strengths may be limited—my colleagues are, no doubt, thinking of some specific examples as I say this. More importantly, collaboration is more productive, and I believe that the quality of the work itself benefits greatly when it is done jointly.

I am deeply grateful to the many people with whom I have collaborated over the past twenty years, knowing full well that any attempt to mention them all risks injustice through omission.

First, I thank my fellow professors in the department, the faculty, and the faculty board for entrusting me with this professorship. I am honoured by your confidence, and I sincerely hope you will not come to regret it.

To my colleagues in the *Data Quality Research Group*: you are the best colleagues with whom one could hope to conduct research. Working with you on papers or grant proposals never feels like work—it is a joy. We share a deep enthusiasm for organising workshops and conferences; for me, co-organising the ESRA conference here in Utrecht last summer was truly a highlight of my career at this university. I hope we can continue working together for many years to come on improving data quality—there remains much to do. My special thanks go also to our long-standing partners at Statistics Netherlands, especially Barry Schouten and Vera Toepoel, for the many fruitful years of collaboration.

I also wish to thank all my colleagues with whom I have shared teaching responsibilities. In recent years I have been teaching somewhat less, and I genuinely regret that, for what I enjoy most in my work is precisely teaching: guiding a seminar or computer practical in which students visibly grasp a concept. Witnessing them suddenly *see* why we spend weeks on regression analysis, or how cognitive interviewing can so greatly improve a questionnaire—that is immensely rewarding. I thank my colleagues and the students—several of whom are present here today—for these experiences.

Work for me is more than teaching and research alone. I greatly value the everyday conversations at the coffee machine, especially in the early mornings—discussions about life, about the difficulties students face, about new R-packages, about the sense or nonsense of testing assumptions in statistics, or about what is happening in the university. I am profoundly grateful to work in the Department of Methodology and Statistics, a place where education is at the heart of academic life, where colleagues willingly solve practical problems together, and where people are always ready to help one another when things become difficult. I count myself lucky to have worked for so many years in such an environment.

Two people deserve particular mention: my PhD supervisors Gerty Lensvelt and Joop Hox. I am delighted that you are both here today. Gerty, from you I learned to think carefully about ambition—and how to deal with the hundred thousand things that inevitably confront a scholar. Joop, from you I learned a great deal about statistical modelling, and about the importance of remaining curious—always—about new methods and approaches.

Work is important to me, but it is not my whole life. More important still are the people outside work. My parents—my father, who sadly passed away many years ago, and my mother—encouraged me from an early age to explore new things, to give myself space, and always supported the choices I made. I thank you both profoundly.

To my friends from secondary school and university, and to the companions of countless concerts, parties, and festivals—you make life joyful and light.

To Wouter, Ellen, and the entire Birkhoff family, who are always there when something needs building or when there is something to celebrate—thank you.

And here, sitting in the front row, are my children, Brun and Nore.

Brun—to prepare for secondary school, you recently spent a day shadowing me at work. You sat beside me all day while I answered emails and attended meetings; I am not sure if that experience made you eager to come to university yourself one day. You are an open book—not only to me but to everyone—and wonderfully kind. I hope you never lose that quality.

Nore, my energetic multi-tasker—always crafting, baking, or creating something new, always eager to do things together. I admire your zest for life and your certainty about what you want and why.

And finally, Marleen—we have been together for eighteen years. I admire your perseverance, your focus, and the love you share so freely. I must apologise for all the evenings in recent months that I spent working late. But tonight, I promise, will not be one of them.